



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

THEY HEAR THE TRAIN A-COMIN’

Passengers wait on the platform to board one of the first subway cars to arrive at the Wilshire/Fairfax station during Friday’s official grand opening of Metro’s D Line extension project. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Virginia maps rejected, boosting GOP

State Supreme Court overturns voter-approved redistricting favoring Democrats.

By Kevin Rector and Ben Wiedner

WASHINGTON — In a blow to the electoral hopes of Democrats in this year’s midterm elections, the Virginia Supreme Court on Friday struck down a redistricting plan that voters in the state had approved last month.

The plan was expected to help Democrats win as many as four additional congressional seats amid an escalating, nationwide battle for control of Congress, in which political leaders in numerous other states — including California — have redrawn their own legislative maps for political advantage.

Experts said the ruling, reached on narrow grounds, prevents Virginia Democrats from using a redrawn map in their favor in the November midterms but does not bar them from making another attempt for future elections.

Just last week, a U.S. Supreme Court ruling severely weakened a Voting Rights Act prohibition on racial discrimination in voting, which has set off numerous efforts in Southern states to redraw legislative maps to the advantage of Republicans.

Friday’s ruling in Virginia, taken together with the Supreme Court ruling, gives Republicans the overall advantage in the broader race, said Larry Sabato, director of the University of Virginia’s Center for Politics.

“They have won the redistricting war, not just in Virginia, but nationally,” he said.

Democrats could still win control of the U.S. House of Representatives, he said, but “we’re not talking about a landslide.”

Amy Walter, publisher and editor in chief of the Cook Political Report, said that although Republicans have gained a structural advantage in November through redistricting, the political climate still favors Democrats.

[See Virginia, A8]

Alabama enters redistricting fight

A special U.S. House primary will be held if courts approve a GOP-drawn map. **NATION, A8**

‘DARK MONEY’ ADS SWAMP L.A. RACES

Adopting tactic from state and national politics, shadowy nonprofit targets leftist local candidates

By David Zahniser

The first time Highland Park resident Paul Zappia received a mailer criticizing Eunisses Hernandez, his representative on the Los Angeles City Council, he tossed it in the trash.

Then another arrived in his mailbox. And another, and another after that. Each came from a group called Neighbors First, which has been attacking Hernandez, a democratic socialist, over her votes against police hiring and her opposition to a law barring homeless encampments near schools.

Zappia, who supports Hernandez in the June 2 primary, said he looked up Neighbors First on its website but couldn’t find any information — not a staff directory, a phone number or even an email address — about the group.

“It is really frustrating that groups like these can spend a lot of money in a local race, but that it is almost impossible for me to find anything out about them,” the 36-year-old graphic designer said.

Zappia and other L.A. voters are getting their first major taste of “dark money,” with well-funded groups weighing in on local candidates — all while keeping their donors anonymous. The

Supreme Court paved the way for the phenomenon in a series of rulings, concluding that political spending is free speech.

In L.A., Neighbors First has sent mail pieces boosting more moderate City Council candidates and criticizing those backed by the Democratic Socialists of America, which pursues leftist policies. Because it is a 501(c)(4) charitable organization, Neighbors First doesn’t have to say who paid for those messages.

On the Westside, the group has offered praise for Councilmember Traci Park, who is seeking to fend off a challenge from DSA-backed attorney Faizah Malik. In South L.A., the group has sent mail pieces critical of Estuardo Mazariegos, who is running to replace Councilmember Curren Price with the DSA support.

A second group, which goes by the name American Middle Ground, appears to be taking a similar approach, sending glossy mailers that promote Park and attack Hernandez over their stances on public safety and homelessness. Its mail pieces and website don’t identify its donors.

[See Dark money, A9]



A PUPIL by the grave of Mahsa Ranjbar, a teacher hit in a strike in Minab, Iran.

COLUMN ONE

A missile strike on a school, then overwhelming grief

Text and photographs by Zohreh Saberi

REPORTING FROM MINAB, IRAN

Posters featuring the faces of the children and their teachers — often smiling — now line the boulevards and main square of Minab, a city that has been submerged in a state of perpetual mourning.

They died in a missile strike on the Shajareh Tayyibeh Elementary School on Feb. 28, the first day of U.S. and Israeli bombardments in Iran. Among the dead were 120 students, 26 teachers and several parents who had rushed to the school to retrieve their children after hearing reports of airstrikes on Tehran. Most arrived too late.

In all, local authorities say, 156 died, including one teacher, Zohreh Shahryari, who was six months pregnant. It is the war’s deadliest attack on civilians.

Iranian state media have put the death toll at 168 or higher, but Ebrahim Taheri, the prosecutor of Minab, provided a breakdown of the 156 deaths local authorities counted.

Among the students, there were 73 boys and 47 girls. All 26 teachers were women. Also counted were seven parents, a school bus driver, a pharmacy technician from an adjacent clinic and the 6-month-old fetus

[See Bombing, A4]

Cyberattack wreaks havoc at state’s colleges

The hack of the widely used Canvas learning platform hits right before finals.

By Jaweed Kaleem and Queenie Wong

A massive data breach at the company behind Canvas, one of the nation’s most widely used education technology platforms, stirred chaos across California campuses this week, interrupting classes, assignments and finals preparations for hundreds of thousands of students and professors as hackers threatened to release their personal data.

By Friday, the cyberattack at Utah-based Instructure, which operates the learning management system used by thousands of schools nationwide — including University of California, California State University and community college districts — was largely contained and most of the

platform was back in operation, the firm said.

But some campuses were still restricting access Friday, as the crippling breach raised broader questions about how universities can protect student data and keep classes running while relying on centralized third-party tech platforms.

The platform is crucial to communications and workflow among students and professors, and Instructure touts that 8,000 institutions rely on it across the globe. Canvas is where reading assignments and lecture notes are posted. It’s often used to conduct classes, take quizzes and tests, submit coursework, join discussion boards, and chat with teachers. When it shut down, work virtually halted as frantic students and instructors scrambled to make adjustments to deadlines and tests.

“I started getting emails from panicked undergrads,” said May-lee Chai, a San Francisco State creative writing professor. She sent [See Breach, A9]

A far-right sheriff shakes up the race

Bianco’s anti-crime message resonates, but some see him as an affront to rule of law.

By Kevin Rector and Hailey Wang

Chad Bianco’s campaign for California governor leans heavily on his years as Riverside County sheriff, a record that has drawn praise from voters yearning to return to a tough-on-crime era and harsh criticism from others who consider him a far-right affront to the rule of law.

The stout, mustached Republican is running an unapologetic campaign against the “Democrat policies that have destroyed this state,” launching into angry diatribes about, as he sees it,

the left’s failed record in California in debate after debate, on social media and in news interviews, during which where he often accuses the media of being complicit.

In an interview with The Times, Bianco said he is sick of what he calls soft-on-crime Democrats in Sacramento undermining him and other law enforcement leaders across the state, whom he wants to unleash if given the power.

Part of Bianco’s prescription for turning California around: cracking down on theft and drug offenses, stiffening sentences for both petty and violent crime, building more detention facilities, collaborating with federal immigration forces to deport immigrant offenders, and demanding greater personal accountability [See Bianco, A11]

Nevada gambling hub folds as game changes

By Andrew J. Campa

Once upon a time, Primm, Nev., had three bustling casino resorts, shiny gas stations, a roller coaster and Bonnie and Clyde’s “death car.”

It was a bit surreal, said former visitor John Honell of West Covina: “You had this whole complex in the middle of the desert.”

Southern Californians traveling the arid stretches of the 15 Freeway would see Primm pop up. As he drove to Sin City for bowling tournaments, Honell would stop and “drop a few coins” into the slot machines. It was a gambling oasis — a little less flashy and a little more af-

fordable than Vegas and 45 minutes closer.

“I guess it worked for a while,” said Honell, 85.

But no longer. The last of the three casino resorts will close on July 4, owner Affinity Gaming confirmed to The Times this week.

Honell, a regular in the 1970s, saw the growth of a desert gamble: the expansion of the Primm property, in the dusty town once known as State Line, from Whiskey Pete’s gas station, bar and slot machines into three busy resorts.

The Nevada gambling hub south of Las Vegas along the I-15 appears finished, though. Southern Californians who appreciate [See Primm, A11]

Vow to fire CNN anchors alleged

Press groups demand to see Paramount’s books over purported favors to Trump. **BUSINESS, A12**

Search continues for Kristin Smart

Investigators detect the presence of human remains but haven’t found a body. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

They fought, but Lakers are done

Despite valiant effort, Thunder are just too much, Bill Plaschke writes. **SPORTS, B12**

Weather
Some sun.
L.A. Basin: 77/58. **B8**

